[DRAFT] A partnership guide to developing a conservation blueprint

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This guide covers logistical aspects of developing a conservation blueprint within an existing conservation partnership. For technical documentation, please see the Southeast Conservation Blueprint 2023 development process and the Midwest Conservation Blueprint 2023 development process.

Uses of a conservation blueprint

People and organizations use conservation blueprints in many ways at different scales:

- Connecting conservation efforts across state lines
- Prioritizing areas for restoration and protection
- Describing how a project proposal connects with the larger landscape
- Helping local governments plan for growth and expand recreational access
- Informing renewable energy siting as part of state and regional tools
- See the SECAS in Action story map for more examples (update coming soon)

Minimum capacity needed

Three full-time permanent positions:

- **Science Coordinator -** Coordinates the overall project and technical approach.
- **GIS Coordinator -** Focuses on GIS processing and integration of existing information, filling gaps where needed, and data management.
- **User Support -** Helps people use the blueprint, tracks blueprint uses, and helps ensure user feedback drives future blueprint improvements.

Conservation blueprints are all about relationships and shared learning. So, it’s best for blueprint staff to do the work of creating and updating the blueprint instead of contracting that out. That way, they can quickly respond to user feedback and develop long-term relationships with people in the conservation community.

Time to create the first version of a blueprint

With the minimum capacity described, and if integrating with other regional blueprints, developing a first version of a conservation blueprint should take about a year. This is how long it took the Midwest Landscape Initiative to create the Midwest Conservation Blueprint while integrating with the existing Southeast Conservation Blueprint.

Keys to success

Integrate with other regional blueprints while maintaining local identity

Integrating with existing regional blueprints allows a partnership to avoid “reinventing the wheel” while still customizing the approach to fit their region. The Midwest Conservation Blueprint uses very similar methods, language, and information to the Southeast Conservation Blueprint, but also uses some different ecosystem indicators, methods, and wording that better suit the Midwest. This allows for tight integration between the regions while still maintaining a local identity.

Build off of existing information

Whenever possible, use existing data—especially data that are being maintained and updated over time. A core function of a conservation blueprint is to synthesize existing information into a holistic plan for a connected network of lands and waters. Using existing data links a blueprint to familiar, vetted information on the species and ecosystems of the area. It also uses staff time more efficiently.

Support users and track outcomes

Dedicated capacity to help people use the blueprint is critical. User support staff help the partnership understand how well a blueprint is working and which improvements are most useful. It also results in shareable stories about how the blueprint is being used, which build momentum and support.

Update regularly

Regular updates help a blueprint keep pace with landscape change, respond to user feedback, and learn from the best available information. The Southeast and Midwest Conservation Blueprints update every year. Updates also build trust and comfort with moving forward in the face of uncertainty and imperfect data because people know that there will be an opportunity to address problems in the next cycle. That message is further reinforced when staff make improvements the following year.

Document known issues

No blueprint is ever perfect. Publicly documenting known issues can clearly communicate that. Known issues also help allay concerns that a problem in the blueprint will negatively impact important conservation work. For example, a known issue may be that imperiled aquatic species are underprioritized in a specific river. If people are asked why they're working on imperiled aquatic species in an area that's not a blueprint priority, they can point out that known issue.

Seek input from experts

In addition to incorporating feedback from blueprint users, intentionally seeking input from experts and conservation practitioners also yields valuable insights to inform the revision cycle and opportunities to build buy-in. The Southeast Conservation Blueprint does this primarily through indicator review teams that bring together subject matter experts on a particular ecosystem or issue (e.g., park equity), and through annual workshops to review the Blueprint that are open to the entire conservation community. The Midwest Blueprint also uses an app to capture feedback at any time.

Consider data accessibility, transparency, and usability

For a blueprint to achieve its goal of informing conservation decisions and bringing in new resources, the data must be publicly accessible, transparently documented, and easy to use. People will not use data that they cannot find, interpret, or trust. A partnership can accomplish this by making blueprint data and documentation available through multiple avenues, including a custom viewer like the Southeast Blueprint Explorer, an ArcGIS Online Hub with web map services like the Midwest Conservation Action Portal, and downloadable data packages from an official archive like ScienceBase. User support staff are also critical in helping make sure data are accessible and easy to use.